

experience of early motherhood. Depending on when you imagine having children, you could even invest this money in order to achieve maximum growth, and sacrificing a small amount of money from your salary early on will make a big difference later.

If you already have children, that last paragraph may have given you flashbacks of struggling to manage financially through maternity pay and childcare, as it did me. But we all know that there are new costs for every stage, and starting to put money aside for the different things that your children will need can really take some of the stress out of family life. For example, in the same way that you might save throughout the year for car insurance, council tax or any other annual expense (many people call these sinking funds, and they work brilliantly for removing some of the bumps in your financial calendar), you could create saving pots for back to school, Christmas, birthdays and the summer holidays. Take a moment to calculate some estimated costs for these expensive events in the year, and then work out how much you would need to contribute to each, monthly. Then, see if there's space in your budget to work this in. Operating in this way, even just for some of these more costly times of the year, will help you to prevent cycles of debt and an over-reliance on credit cards, but will improve your overall financial confidence too. As with all of your saving habits, automating these small contributions just after you get paid will take most of the effort out of the process for you.